WILLIAMSTOWN, UNITED STATES

Clark Art Institute: Masterpieces

Twenty works in which cloth, tools, ground and light give a figure something to do.



A crocheting woman does not need to look up for the portrait to hold together. Her task supplies a pose. A rider in the White Mountains has to negotiate rocky ground; a girl arranging her hair gives a pale interior its clearest movement. These paintings obtain their character from particular relations between bodies and the things close to them.

The still lifes make a related demand without people. An onion’s dry skin and a folded cloth need different marks; a black shadow can distinguish one grape from another. The selection follows that practical attention across polished mythological figures, loosely described landscapes and portraits that leave much of their surroundings unstated.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/clark-art-institute

The selection · 20

1. Madonna and Child Attended by Angels
   Piero della Francesca · 1475
2. Nymphs and Satyr
   William-Adolphe Bouguereau · c. 1873
3. Blonde Bather
   Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1881
4. Onions
   Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1881
5. Woman Crocheting
   Pierre-Auguste Renoir · c. 1875
6. The Bridle Path, White Mountains
   Winslow Homer · 1868
7. What You Will!
   J. M. W. Turner · 1822
8. View off Margate, Evening
   J. M. W. Turner · c. 1840
9. Self-Portrait in a Soft Hat
   Edgar Degas · 1858
10. The Bath: Girl Arranging Her Hair
    Berthe Morisot · 1886
11. Elizabeth and Thomas Linley
    Thomas Gainsborough · c. 1768
12. A Wooded Landscape with Figures by a House
    Thomas Gainsborough · c. 1752
13. Flatford Mill from the Lock
    John Constable · c. 1810
14. The Wheat Field
    John Constable · 1816
15. The Loing and the Mills of Moret, Snow Effect
    Alfred Sisley · 1891
16. Apples and Grapes in a Basket
    Alfred Sisley · 1876
17. Lilies
    Albert Moore · 1866
18. The Warrior
    Jean-Honoré Fragonard · 1769
19. The Amorous Proposal
    François Lemoyne · 1725
20. Sarah Bernhardt
    Dudley Hardy · 1889

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Madonna and Child Attended by Angels

Piero della Francesca

1475 · Clark Art Institute



Piero della Francesca. Madonna and Child Attended by Angels. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The pale architectural enclosure keeps the figures in a measured relation, with clear spaces around their bodies. Small gestures become conspicuous against that steadiness. Piero gives the sacred group a structure in which attention need not be carried by large action; a limited movement can matter because the setting does not compete with it.

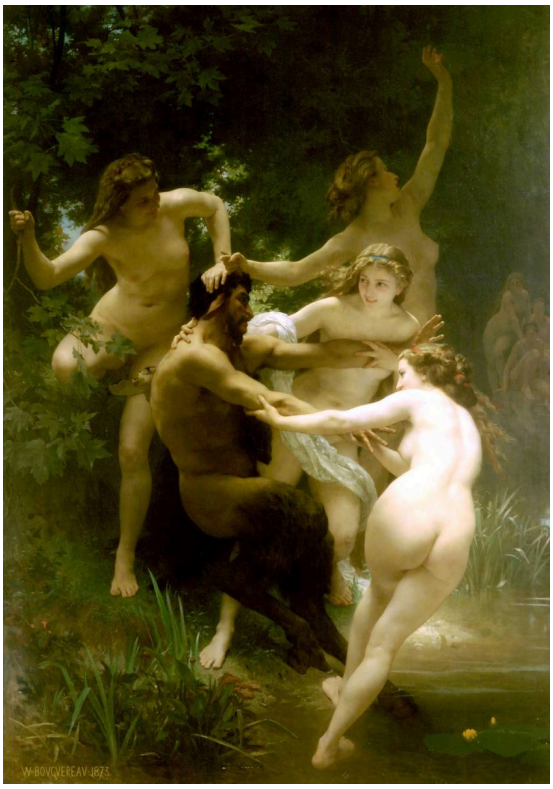
Object source · Open artwork

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Nymphs and Satyr

William-Adolphe Bouguereau

c. 1873 · Oil on canvas · Clark Art Institute



William-Adolphe Bouguereau. Nymphs and Satyr. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/william-adolphe-bouguereau/nymphs-and-satyr · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The nymphs' grips and the satyr's resistance form a linked chain at the water's edge. Smoothly modelled bodies make changes of weight easy to follow even where the figures crowd together. The mythological subject depends on practical bodily relations: pulling, pushing and finding support are what turn the assembly into an episode.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Blonde Bather

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1881 · Oil on canvas · Clark Art Institute



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Blonde bather. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pierre-auguste-renoir/blonde-bather-1881 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The seated body is more continuously modelled than the landscape behind it. White cloth gathered across the lap provides another surface close to the skin. The difference in handling keeps the bather prominent without requiring the surrounding water and rocks to disappear; they remain a distinct register within the same view.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Onions

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1881 · Oil on canvas · Clark Art Institute



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Onions. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pierre-auguste-renoir/onions-1881 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Onion skins, garlic and crumpled cloth offer several sorts of surface within a modest arrangement. Warm light helps the rounded bulbs emerge, while looser strokes connect table and background. The subject's familiarity makes the distinctions easier to test: fabric does not fold like dry skin, and neither behaves like a flat tabletop.

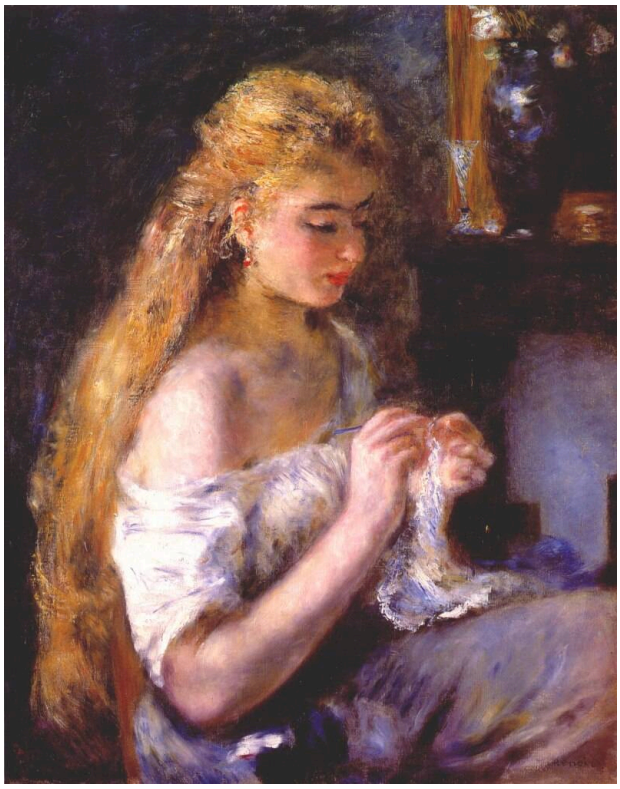
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Woman Crocheting

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

c. 1875 · Clark Art Institute



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Girl crocheting. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pierre-auguste-renoir/girl-crocheting · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The woman’s attention stays with the work held near her chest. Eyes and fingers give the pose a purpose without an exchange of looks with the spectator. The pale blouse and darker skirt frame that small activity, allowing concentration to be described as a bodily arrangement rather than a guess about her private thoughts.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Bridle Path, White Mountains

Winslow Homer

1868 · Clark Art Institute



Winslow Homer. The Bridal Path, White Mountains. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The pale horse must carry its rider across uneven foreground rock before the distant mountains can become a pleasant prospect. Smaller figures continue along the path behind. Homer keeps travel attached to the landscape's surface: the place offers a view, but it is also ground that has to be negotiated.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

What You Will!

J. M. W. Turner

1822 · Clark Art Institute



J. M. W. Turner. What You Will!. Image credit: J. M. W. Turner; Source credit: Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The brightly costumed figures occupy only part of a view given breadth by vegetation and warm light. Their gathering remains less easy to summarise than a single decisive action. Turner allows the social scene to share attention with its surroundings, so that the landscape does not become merely a decorative setting for the people.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2007.8.107

08 / 20

View off Margate, Evening

J. M. W. Turner

c. 1840 · Clark Art Institute



J. M. W. Turner. View off Margate, Evening. Image credit: J. M. W. Turner; Source credit: https://www.clarkart.edu/ArtPiece/Detail/View-off-Margate,-Evening. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

A few firmer accents let boats and sail remain recognisable within pale water and sky. Other near forms stay loosely indicated. Turner gives the extensive view enough definition to be followed without imposing hard boundaries everywhere; atmosphere is preserved through the different degrees to which objects become available.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2007.8.117

09 / 20

Self-Portrait in a Soft Hat

Edgar Degas

1858 · Oil on canvas · Clark Art Institute



Self Portrait in a Soft Hat. WikiArt; Edgar Degas. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The hat’s shadow does not fall evenly across the face. One eye receives more light, making the apparent directness of the encounter less symmetrical than it first seems. Red scarf and pale coat provide distinct areas below. Degas constructs the likeness through controlled tonal differences rather than a complete, equally lit inventory of features.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

The Bath: Girl Arranging Her Hair

Berthe Morisot

1886 · Oil on canvas · Clark Art Institute



Berthe Morisot. The Bath (Girl Arranging Her Hair). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/berthe-morisot/the-bath-girl-arranging-her-hair · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The raised arms make the action clear even where clothing and surrounding room are lightly stated. Morisot permits the gesture to remain more definite than the place containing it. The picture's open appearance is therefore not simply a lack of information: it gives priority to a passing movement over a fully described interior.

Object source · Open artwork

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Elizabeth and Thomas Linley

Thomas Gainsborough

c. 1768 · Clark Art Institute



Thomas Gainsborough. Elizabeth and Thomas Linley. Image credit: Thomas Gainsborough; Source credit: Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The two young sitters share a close position without sharing an identical expression. Their faces and pale clothing emerge from softer foliage, whose handling keeps the bodies from appearing sharply cut out. The double portrait's relation depends on proximity and difference together, rather than on giving each figure a separate stage.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1955.955

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A Wooded Landscape with Figures by a House

Thomas Gainsborough

c. 1752 · Clark Art Institute



Thomas Gainsborough. A Wooded Landscape with Figures by a House. Image credit: Thomas Gainsborough; Source credit: Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The house and figures provide signs of habitation within a larger wooded setting. Tree masses and changing light organise depth before small human actions become important. Gainsborough allows the dwelling to belong to that continuity, resisting the temptation to isolate it as a picturesque object independent of the land around it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2007.8.81

13 / 20

Flatford Mill from the Lock

John Constable

c. 1810 · Clark Art Institute



John Constable. Flatford Mill from the Lock. Image credit: John Constable; Source credit: Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The lock, buildings and moving surfaces of water establish a landscape with work built into it. Rough marks connect trees, banks and reflections without making the structures interchangeable. Constable keeps the mill attached to its river system: its interest is not only in the building's appearance, but in the relations that give it a place.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2007.8.23

14 / 20

The Wheat Field

John Constable

1816 · Clark Art Institute



John Constable. The Wheat Field. Image credit: John Constable; Source credit: Sterling and Francine Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Harvesters are distributed across a field large enough to prevent any one figure from taking over. Their activities remain significant as parts of a shared task. Broad bands of field, trees and sky organise the distance, keeping labour within the scale of countryside rather than turning it into an isolated anecdote.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2007.8.27

15 / 20

The Loing and the Mills of Moret, Snow Effect

Alfred Sisley

1891 · Clark Art Institute



Alfred Sisley. The Loing and the Mills of Moret, Snow Effect. Image credit: Alfred Sisley; Source credit: Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Snow, buildings and water occupy a narrow range of cold colours, but do not become one undifferentiated surface. Reflections loosen the architecture’s shapes while thin verticals interrupt the sky. Sisley preserves movement and depth through small distinctions, making limited colour a condition for closer looking rather than a restriction to overcome.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1955.545

16 / 20

Apples and Grapes in a Basket

Alfred Sisley

1876 · Clark Art Institute



Alfred Sisley. Apples and Grapes in a Basket. Image credit: Alfred Sisley; Source credit: Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Woven basket, grapes, apples and draped cloth demand different sorts of description. Cool shadows keep them connected while the fruit retains separate rounded forms. Sisley’s loose marks do not remove those material distinctions. The still life is held together by their coexistence, not by making everything equally smooth or equally fragmented.

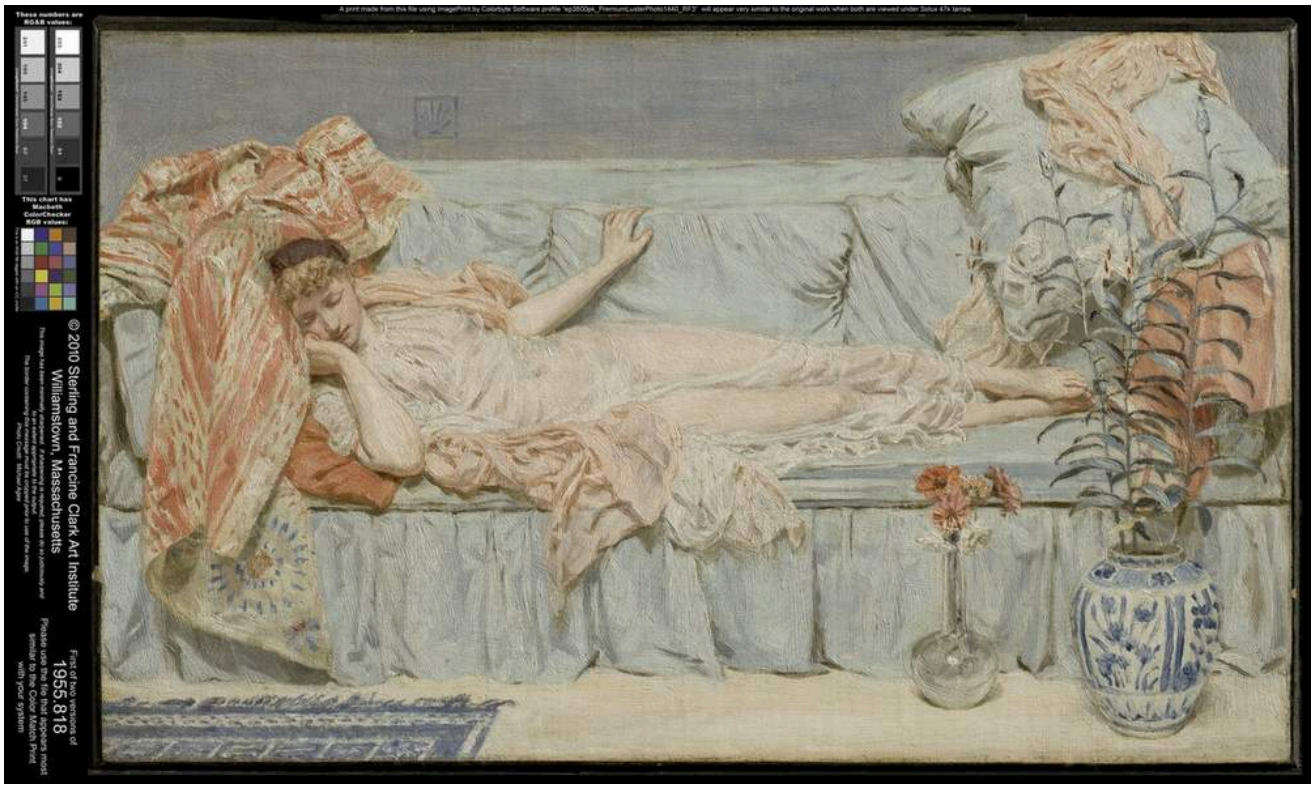
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1955.543

17 / 20

Lilies

Albert Moore

1866 · Clark Art Institute



Albert Joseph Moore. Lilies. Image credit: Albert Joseph Moore; Source credit: Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The reclining body extends through flowers and patterned textiles in related pale tones. Figure and furnishing share curves and colour, giving the arrangement more emphasis than a particular narrated event. Moore allows a person to remain recognisable while becoming part of the picture’s larger distribution of decorative forms.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1955.818

18 / 20

The Warrior

Jean-Honoré Fragonard

1769 · Oil on canvas · Clark Art Institute



The Warrior. WikiArt; Jean-Honoré Fragonard. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The turn gives the figure an energy unlike a pose held with complete stillness. Bright sleeves and white ruff catch the light around the yellow costume, while broader handling leaves the exact role theatrical. The title supplies a warrior, but the painting’s immediate force lies in dress and movement rather than an account of battle.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

The Amorous Proposal

François Lemoyne

1725 · Clark Art Institute



François Lemoyne. The Amorous Proposal. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The older man leans toward the young woman, whose turn and hands complicate the approach. Elegant surroundings do not establish that their attentions are equal or affection mutual. The relation has to be read through the bodies themselves, with enough uncertainty retained to avoid converting the title into an uncomplicated conclusion.

Object source · Open artwork

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Sarah Bernhardt

Dudley Hardy

1889 · Clark Art Institute



Dudley Hardy. Sarah Bernhardt. Image credit: Dudley Hardy; Source credit: Clark Art Institute. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The long pale figure partly merges with the lightly described room. A small darker accent around the head and the elongated silhouette are enough to preserve the sitter’s presence. Hardy does not require precise domestic surroundings for the portrait to cohere; the allocation of definition gives the person priority over the setting.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1955.760

Keep one material or gesture in view

Follow occupied hands from crocheting to arranging hair, or compare the different treatment of cloth in the Renoir bather and the onion still life. A narrow comparison can reveal more than a hurried survey of all twenty works. Check the Clark's current collection information before planning around a particular object or display.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

This freely available Metropolitan Museum catalogue supplies historical context for Renoir, Degas, Morisot and Sisley. Its object discussions help separate their different treatments of figures and landscapes.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12